Contextual interview planning guide

Overview

In the first stage of the human-centered design process, we try to understand who are going to be potential users of the product we will design, and what are their needs, goals, current ways of doing things, challenges they face, strategies they use to overcome these challenges, and the technologies they use to achieve their goals. One way to learn about the users of the product is to conduct contextual interviews. These are interviews that are carried out in the context of where the interaction is expected to happen. They also include observations of the environment and of activities that users carry out in their everyday lives. This can help us design products that would fit into their lives.

1. Interview Study Goal

Define what you are trying to achieve in carrying out a contextual interview study. This goal should be aligned with your project goals. For contextual interviews, the goal is typically related to understanding the current motivations, practices, challenges, and needs of a specific group of people, with respect to the focus of the problem space, the product, or the design challenge.

2. Participants

Define who would be the participants in the contextual interview, and how many are needed: small-scale projects often include 5-10 participants; large-scale, complex, or high-stakes projects would include 20-40 participants.

End-users: Ideally, your participants would be people who are expected to use the product you will design. Define how you would screen for the right participants: what would be the criteria for eligibility to participate in the evaluation and how/when you would do the screening.

Other people impacted by the product: Sometimes, the product you will design will have an impact on other people in the community beyond its end-users. In this case, it would be beneficial to interview those additional people. For example, in a workplace, it is important to interview colleagues and supervisors of the employees who are end-users. In a domestic context, consider interviewing family members or housemates. In educational contexts, you'll need the perspectives of students, educators, and administrators. These individuals may have additional perspectives about constraints related to using the system, such as access, costs, and schedules. They might also have decision making power related to purchasing and/or accessing the product (e.g., parents, employers, administrators).

Subject-matter experts: In case access to end-users is limited, companies sometimes employ people who are deeply familiar with the problem space and with the end-users' goals, backgrounds, motivations, perspectives, activities, and behaviors. Remember, however, that subject-matter experts represent "power users", and not a beginner or casual user, because they are deeply invested in the product.

3. Recruitment

Decide on the most effective recruitment method and compose the content of the recruitment message. You may also combine recruitment methods to reach a broader audience.

Recruitment method options include:

- ***In-person announcements***: especially if the participant group has a place where individuals go to, such as a meeting place.
- ***Paper flyers:*** you could design them using marketing flyer templates, print them out, and post them in prominent areas where individuals from the user group are likely to visit. A version of this is ***handouts or paper slips*** that are printed and given to people.
- ***Social media:*** posting messages on social media applications is a cheap way to reach a wide audience. However, this method will likely reach people in your own personal network, who may not necessarily fit the characteristics of individuals you are looking for.
- ***Email:*** email messages sent individually or through a mailing list are another cheap way to reach a wide audience. In the case of a mailing list, find out if you need special permission to post on the list, and if yes, find the gatekeeper or administrator who would give you access to the list or forward your message to the list.
- ***Word-of-mouth or snowball recruitment:*** ask participants in your study if they can help you identify and connect to others who would be willing to participate.

The ***recruitment message*** should fit in content, style, and length to the recruitment method you have chosen, and should include:

- Purpose of study interview
- What kind of participants you are looking for and any eligibility criteria
- Location, time, and length of interview study
- What would happen at the interview study
- Any compensation offered to participants
- Your contact information

4. Location, Time & logistics

Always plan a contextual interview to take place ***in the context*** where you expect the interaction with the product to happen: at home, the workplace, on the move, etc. This allows the interviewer to observe the participants in their natural environment and engage them in "show and tell". The participant is also more likely to feel comfortable and in control, which will result in more genuine answers at the interview.

Plan the study to take about 30-60 minutes, which depends on the amount of questions you plan to ask and activities you plan to observe, and on the depth of your interactions with the participant. The time of the interview should be when the participant is available, so you'll need to plan your schedule around that.

5. Informed Consent

Plan the protocol for obtaining informed consent. See ***informed consent guidelines*** tool.

6. Data Collection

Define what data will be collected at the contextual interview and how the data will be captured.

- ***Note-taking:*** these can be done in a notebook or on a laptop. Notebook is considered more personable, because the note-taker is not hiding behind a laptop screen, and the participant can see what they are scribbling in the notebook. It is not recommended to facilitate the interview and take notes at the same time, because it is difficult to actively listen to the interviewee and take notes at the same time.
- ***Audio/video-recording:*** the advantage is capturing *everything* that the participant is saying (audio) or saying and doing (video), and the lack of need for a separate note-taker at the interview.

- ***Taking photos:*** use this as a supplementary data collection technique, to capture details about the environment and the context, and objects and activities the participant is showing you at the interview.

7. Ethical Considerations

In planning the contextual interview, pay attention to ethical issues. See ***Best Practices in Ethical User Research*** handout.

8. List of materials

Create a list of everything you need to bring to the interview; e.g., printouts of the protocol and informed consent form, recording equipment, extra batteries, gift.